The Happy Prince

The big idea

Oscar Wilde's fairy tale is about a golden statue, the **Happy Prince**, and a little **Swallow**. From his high pedestal the Prince sees the misery of the poor and, with the Swallow's help, gives away his jewels and gold. Both sacrifice everything and are rewarded by God. The story celebrates **compassion and sacrifice**, and criticises a society that values outward beauty.

Summary

1. The statue of the Happy Prince stands high above the city. It is covered with thin leaves of **fine gold**, has two bright **sapphires** for eyes and a large red **ruby** on his sword-hilt. People admire it.
2. A **Swallow**, delayed because he had fallen in love with a **Reed**, is flying to **Egypt** six weeks after his friends. He rests between the Prince's feet and feels drops of water: the Prince is **weeping**.
3. The Prince explains that when alive, he lived in the **Palace of Sans-Souci**, where sorrow was not allowed. Now, set up high, he sees all the ugliness and misery of the city, and though his heart is made of **lead**, he cannot help weeping.
4. **Ruby**: The Prince asks the Swallow to take the ruby to a poor **seamstress** whose little son lies ill with fever and asks for oranges. The Swallow fans the boy with his wings.
5. **First sapphire**: He sends one eye to a young **playwright** in a cold garret, too hungry and cold to finish a play for the Director of the Theatre.
6. **Second sapphire**: He sends the other eye to a little **match-girl** whose matches fell into the gutter; her father would beat her. The Prince is now **blind**, and the Swallow decides to stay with him always.

7. **Gold leaf**: The Swallow tells the Prince of the poor and hungry in the city. The Prince asks him to strip off his **gold leaf**, piece by piece, and give it to the poor. The children grow rosier and laugh.
8. Winter comes. The Swallow grows weaker, kisses the Prince on the lips and **falls dead** at his feet. At that moment the Prince's **leaden heart snaps in two**.
9. The **Mayor and Town Councillors** find the statue shabby. The Art Professor says that since it is no longer beautiful it is no longer useful. They **melt** it down, but the broken **lead heart** will not melt and is thrown on a dust heap beside the dead Swallow.
10. God asks an angel to bring the **two most precious things** in the city. The angel brings the **leaden heart** and the **dead bird**. God says the bird will sing in the garden of Paradise and the Prince will praise Him in the city of gold.

Characters

- **The Happy Prince**: compassionate, selfless; happy in life only because he never saw sorrow.
- **The Swallow**: initially restless and eager to reach Egypt, he becomes loyal and self-sacrificing out of love for the Prince.
- **The Mayor and Councillors**: vain, shallow, care only for appearance.

Themes

- **Compassion and sacrifice** are true beauty.
- **Inner beauty vs outer beauty**.
- **Social inequality** and the indifference of the rich.

THE PRINCE WAS NOT HAPPY AS A STATUE

He was called "happy" because, in life, he never saw sorrow. As a statue he weeps at the misery he sees.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why was the Prince called happy? Why did he weep? What did he give, and to whom? What were the two most precious things and why? Value points: ruby to seamstress, sapphires to playwright and match-girl, gold leaf to poor.

Quick recap

- Statue of gold, sapphire eyes, ruby on sword.
- Swallow helps him give everything to the poor.
- Both die; God calls the lead heart and dead bird the most precious things.

Practice questions

1. Why was the Prince called the Happy Prince?

   (a) He always smiled (b) In his lifetime he never knew sorrow (c) He gave gifts to everyone (d) He was rich

2. Where was the Swallow going?

   (a) India (b) Greece (c) Egypt (d) Persia

3. To whom did the Swallow take the ruby?

   (a) The match-girl (b) The young playwright (c) The seamstress with a sick son (d) The Mayor

4. Why could the young man in the garret not finish his play?

   (a) He was too cold and hungry to write (b) He had lost his pen (c) The Director had rejected it (d) He was ill with fever

5. What happened to the Prince's heart when the Swallow died?

   (a) It melted (b) It turned to gold (c) It stopped beating (d) The leaden heart snapped in two

6. What did the angel bring to God as the two most precious things?

   (a) The ruby and the sapphires (b) The gold leaf and the sword (c) The leaden heart and the dead bird (d) The statue and the pedestal

7. Why did the Happy Prince weep, though his heart was made of lead?

8. "The story shows that true beauty lies in sacrifice, not in appearance." Discuss.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. c 4. a 5. d 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes